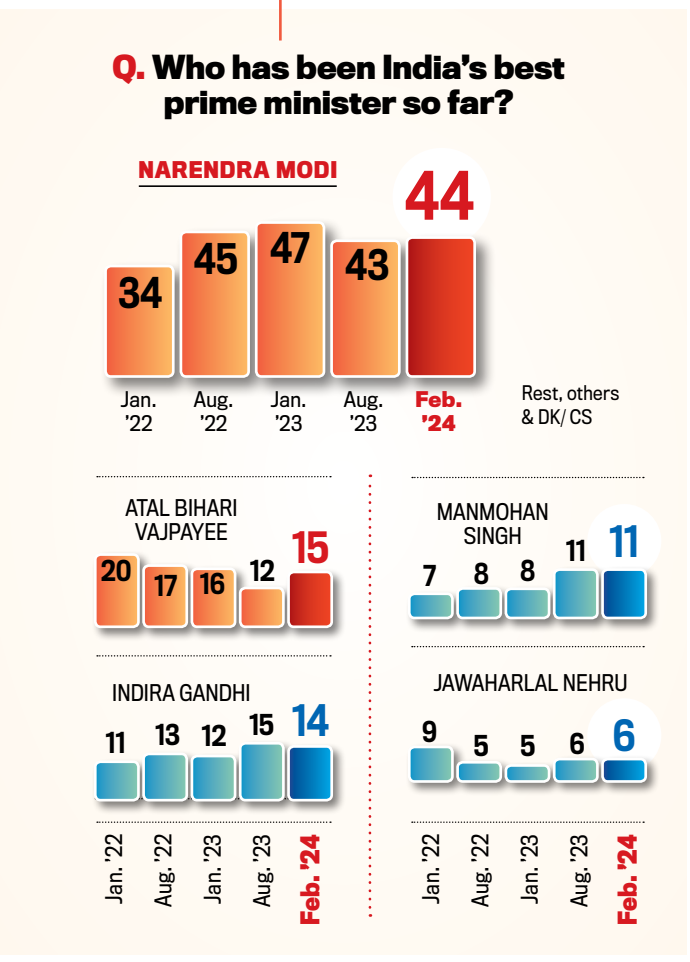
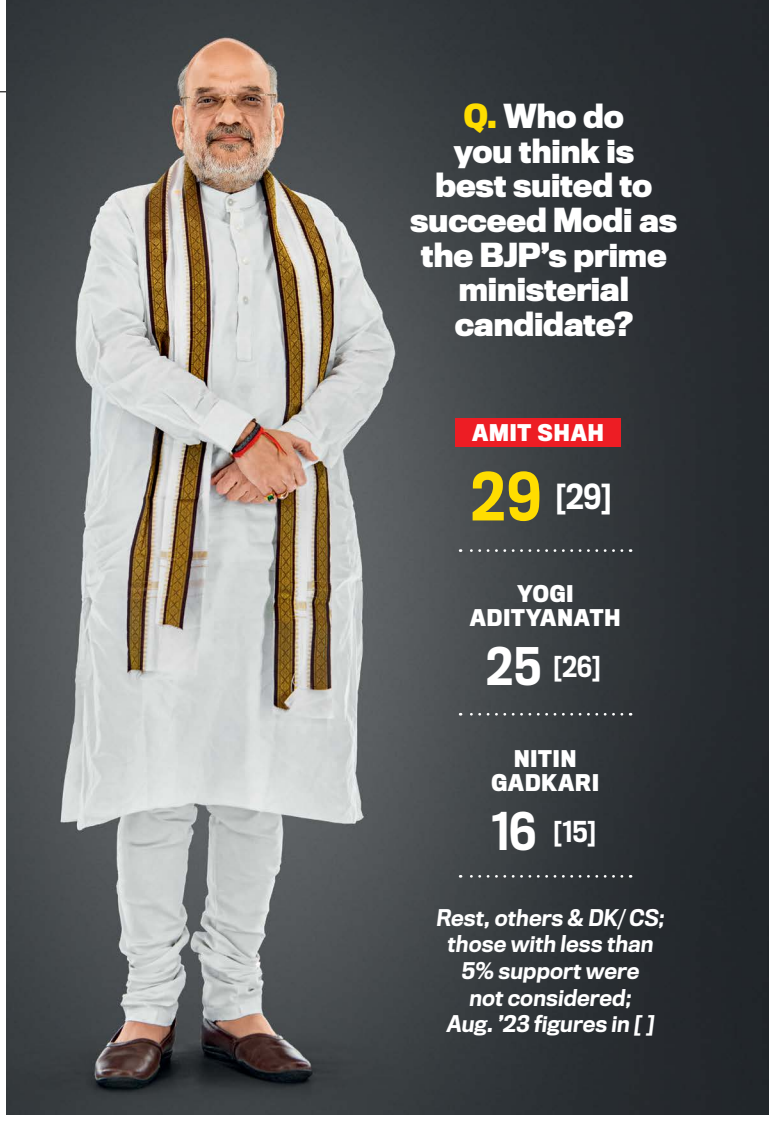




Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

efforts on to hit 370. It is hoping, therefore, to add to its tally in West Bengal where it made major inroads in 2019 by winning 18 of the state's 42 seats; in Uttar Pradesh, where it cornered 62 (71 for NDA) out of its 80 seats; in Odisha, where it won eight of the 21 seats; and in Telangana, where it bagged four of the 17 seats. The BJP and its NDA partners also need to open their account in other big states where they drew a blank—Tamil Nadu, which has 39 seats; Andhra Pradesh (25) and Kerala (20). In the 77 seats in Gujarat (26), Rajasthan (25), Haryana (10), Delhi (7), Uttarakhand (5) and Himachal Pradesh (4), the BJP must repeat the clean sweep it managed in 2019. The party must also aim for a saffron wash in the 96 seats in Madhya Pradesh (where it won 28 out of the 29 seats in 2019), Jharkhand (11 out of 14), Karnataka (25 out of 28), Assam (9 out of 14) and Chhattisgarh (9 out of 11). There are two other key states where the BJP and NDA allies need to win big: Maharashtra (where the BJP won 23 and the NDA 41 out of the 48 seats) and Bihar (where the BJP had 17 in the NDA tally of 39 out of the state's 40 seats).

The only way the BJP can meet its target of 370 is by ensuring that it wins 50 per cent of the votes in the maximum number of states possible. When Rajiv won 404 seats for the Congress in 1984, the party's overall vote share was 49 per cent. By contrast, in 2019, in its best-ever showing of 303, the BJP had only 37.36 per cent of the vote share. The current MOTN predicts its vote share at 39.6 per cent—an increase of two percentage points, but still 10 percentage points short of the Congress's 1984 feat. The NDA combine won a 45 per cent vote share in 2019; this time, the MOTN predicts a marginal fall to 44.4 per cent, though a rise of 1.8 percentage points over the August 2023 figure. The BJP and NDA will have to work in tandem to push the vote percentage up to 50 per cent to reach the magical tally of 400 they are hoping for.

However, even if Modi falls short of his endeavour to equal Rajiv Gandhi's record, the prime minister will still overtake the one set by Indira Gandhi. She had served three terms as prime minister, winning the 1967 and 1971 elections for the Congress with a full majority. But she failed in her bid to secure a third consecutive majority when the Congress lost badly in the 1977